



Module 19

Safety

As a coach, you must be focused on safety. Safety is all-encompassing and includes everything from making sure your client is using proper form on exercises, to reiterating the importance of running only in safe areas. No matter how great a program is on paper, if it does not take safety into consideration, it is a bad program.

This is where preformatted programs often fail. Making assumptions that your client possesses specific skills or a set fitness level can result in an unsafe training practice.

Other important aspects of sport safety include your clients informing someone where they will be training and carrying ID as well as necessary medication and money.

❖ OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this module, you should have an understanding of the following areas:

- Understanding scope of practice and knowledge
- Weather issues
- Implementation of team strategy
- Running safety strategies

❖ SCOPE OF PRACTICE & KNOWLEDGE

Successfully passing this certification will qualify you to advise and educate a client in all areas pertaining to training a runner. It is important to remember there is a big difference between advising/educating and prescribing/diagnosing. As a running coach, you cannot do the following:

- Diagnose or treat an injury or illness
- Prescribe a nutritional or supplementation program in most states unless you are a registered dietician or certified nutritionist
 - Check with local or state laws
- Hands-on muscular (i.e., massage) or skeletal manipulation
- While not illegal, any substantial biomechanical deviation should be referred to a specialist

If you do not feel qualified to advise or educate on a specific area and you decide to proceed anyway, you are practicing outside your scope of knowledge.

This is an important distinction. You can work within your scope of practice but outside your scope of knowledge. Conversely, you can work within your scope of knowledge but outside your scope of practice. An example of someone working within the scope of practice but outside the scope of knowledge would be a running coach whose clients want advice on the difference between two separate shoe brands. While this question is within a running coach's scope of practice, an individual who does not know the answer and proceeds to fabricate one is practicing outside the scope of knowledge.

An example of someone practicing within the scope of knowledge but outside the scope of practice would be a seasoned running coach who is 99.9 percent sure a client has patellofemoral syndrome and manually massages the client's leg to relieve the symptoms. While the running coach may be correct in the "diagnosis," the individual cannot legally diagnose a condition and, moreover, cannot massage the client's leg to relieve the symptoms – even if certain that this will work.

The distinction between what is legal and illegal when working with clients can be unclear. It is always best to err on the side of caution when working with clients and refer them to specialists.

TEAM APPROACH

The legal and professional obligation of a coach to refer clients may also present learning opportunities. Often, a specialist will have advice for a coach as to what protocol to follow or the reasons why a client is experiencing a particular issue.

Knowledge gained in this fashion is invaluable and will help further the development and education of a coach.

It is suggested that a coach coordinate a “team” of specialists to whom he or she feels comfortable referring clients. This team approach generally elicits the best and fastest results for clients as well as releases a coach from potential liability by overstepping professional boundaries.

It is impossible for a coach to have all the resources required by a client. A coach who is not implementing a team approach is not providing clients with the best possible training. Unless a coach is a doctor, physical therapist, registered dietician, podiatrist, sports psychologist, etc., the individual needs other members on the team. Just because a coach has knowledge or experience in a particular area does not necessarily mean that there is not someone better equipped to assist a client in that area. For example, a registered dietician with a focus on endurance sports is likely better suited to advise a client on nutritional strategy than a running coach. This is not a negative reflection on a running coach, but rather demonstrates the specialized expertise of a dietician. Referring clients to others is not a sign of weakness but an indication of a coach’s intelligence and dedication to clients.

WEATHER

Temperature extremes not only negatively affect one’s performance, but can be dangerous as well.

If a client knows that a competition will occur in extreme temperature conditions, the individual needs to safely simulate these temperatures, if possible, during training. Accurately predicting how the body will react and perform in adverse conditions is critical for the safety of a client.

❖ RUNNING SAFETY ISSUES

RUNNING SAFETY

Runners must always stay alert when running on roads and always run on the left-hand side of the road, unless there is a wider shoulder or running lane on the right.

Runners need to be careful not to put themselves in harm's way. Below are several examples of this:

- If running in low light or at night, runners need to wear reflective clothing and have a light source.
- Runners *must* be aware of their surroundings at all times!
- It is not a good idea to run alone in areas that could be considered dangerous. Clients should run only on roads they are familiar with and, ideally, roads that have a wide shoulder or running lane.
- If your client is trail running, instruct the individual always to run with a partner and to know the route. If your client runs in areas that allow hunting, trail running should not be done during hunting season.
- If wearing headphones, make sure to wear only one earpiece or wear headphones that allow for outside noise to be heard.
- When running near parked cars, a runner must be far enough to the side so that if someone opens a door suddenly, the runner will not be hit.
- A client who is asthmatic should always carry a rescue (fast-acting) inhaler.

Hydration is an important area to focus on when discussing safety. Many runners often run long distances without fluids. This can lead to dehydration that can cause serious medical complications. Two ways to prevent this is to carry fluids during a run or to make sure there are stops along a route to get fluids and food. Specific hydration systems are made for runners, such as hydration backpacks,

belts that carry small fluid containers, and handheld bottles with a strap for easy carrying.

It is of crucial importance that a client always has emergency information on hand. Products allow individuals to put their name and emergency information on wrist or ankle bracelets. Additionally, clients should tell someone of their proposed route.

When doing a long run, if possible, a client should bring a cell phone and run in an area that has stops for food and water. This is especially important when running in hot weather.

❖ SUMMARY

- As a running coach, you cannot do the following:
 - Diagnose or treat an injury
 - Prescribe a nutritional or supplementation program in most states unless you are a registered dietician or certified nutritionist
 - Check with local or state laws
 - Any hands-on muscular or skeletal manipulation
 - While not illegal, any substantial biomechanical deviation should be referred to a specialist
- As a coach, you must practice within your scope of practice and knowledge at all times.
- It is never the wrong approach to refer your client to a specialist.
- It is advised to have a team of specialists whom you can refer your clients to.
- When running in low light conditions, reflective clothing and a light source are musts.
- Always run in familiar locations and ideally with a partner.
- Always carry emergency contact information when training and racing.